> I am quite good at talking to young people about human rights but here I have failed miserably … Even trying to say things like "My daughter is three and a half and she is sick and I take her to the hospital. If a Rohingya [Muslim minority group] girl gets sick and desperately needs help, don't you think she should get it?" "No" [they say] … And I tried all these things in my toolbox (Interview 37, 2014 English).

In interactions between Western aid workers and activists and opposition leaders, aid workers often assumed that recognition of universal human rights was an inviolable platform. And when Bamar actors failed to frame dialogue in this category, interaction was often described as no longer being possible. "Nothing works", Michael concluded after failing to establish human rights as a common platform. "I have to admit I really can't discuss this any more. I have to give up. I am really disappointed" (Interview 37, 2014 English).

Along with universal human rights, any vision of democracy is also seen to necessarily embrace acceptance of multiple — especially minority — voices. "In [my country], we say that the measure of a true democracy is not majority rule but how minority voices are heard and incorporated," said another participant (Interview 19, 2013 English). As this quote suggests, the acceptance of multiple voices extends to the respect and protection of minorities. "The more you can respect minorities the better", she continued (Interview 19, 2013 English). Myanmar moving towards clearer protection of the Muslim minority — and other ethnic minority groups such as the Kachin and Karen — was essential for any "genuine" measure of democracy. In this way, for proponents of the *liberal* narrative of democratization in Myanmar, human rights and protection of minorities are values that must be part of the foundation of any future vision of "democracy". Though the structure or procedures of formal democratic institutions may vary, it is essential they are grounded in these liberal values.

I now turn to a set of contrasting interpretations from activists and opposition leaders in the Burmese democracy movement. While respect of human rights and minority protection are perceived by many international aid workers to be necessary components of democracy, among activists, debate commonly focuses on the values of unity and the need for protection of the Bamar majority.